

The Faster Route to an AI-Native ACME

A proposal from Agile ICT

Where you are

ACME is profitable, data-rich and entrepreneurial. Your edge is proprietary sports data and the people who know how to trade on it. Your brief asks exactly the right question: across a profitable group with seven development teams, what should disappear, stay human, become AI-assisted or become agent-executed, and who can be trusted to lead that redesign?

Your plan is to answer it by paying 3 to 5 consultants for 6 to 10 weeks each and appointing a Chief only if someone earns it. The instinct is exactly right: judge people on real execution, not interviews. The risk is in the format.

The risk in the format

On the ranges in your own brief, the audition could consume 18 to 50 candidate-weeks across up to five separately managed engagements: five onboardings, five sets of controlled access to your systems and data, five directions of travel, and management attention from leaders who would rather be running the business. Each candidate builds to demonstrate; only later does someone integrate. The test is real, but the accountability is fragmented, and nobody owns the whole answer until the process is over.

The alternative: keep the test, unify the accountability

Replace the parallel audition for the transformation lead with one accountable engagement. Not a hire, not a headhunt. You put real ACME problems in front of one company and judge us stage by stage on what we deliver, working alongside your seven development teams and whichever implementation and data capability you keep or recruit.

You tell us the biggest constraint in the business right now. If you can't name it in a sentence, that is itself worth knowing, and stage one surfaces it fast. Then we work it, prove the approach, and repeat, so the company changes one removed constraint at a time rather than through a big-bang restructure.

Where we would expect the value to live, as hypotheses for stage one to test rather than conclusions:

1. **The operational layer.** Your brief suggests reporting, management cadence and routine process contain avoidable work. Stage one tests that before any organisational decision is made.
2. **The core engine.** Applying current AI capability to what makes ACME money: sports data products, pricing and odds research, and the decision loops around them.

How it runs

Every stage is a fixed fee against a written statement of work, with the outcomes defined and agreed by both sides before it starts. Your protection is the gate: each stage has to earn the next, and you can stop at any gate and keep everything.

Stage	Length	You pay	You get
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1. Find and baseline	2-3 weeks	[HK\$ fixed fee]	One bounded, high-value constraint agreed and baselined, a working demonstration against it, and a plain-language plan.
2. Deliver the improvement	4-6 weeks	[HK\$ fixed fee]	A measurable improvement against the agreed target, including a production-quality AI workflow where that is the right intervention, with your team using it.
3. Keep compounding	Monthly, fractional	[HK\$ monthly retainer]	Ongoing senior AI leadership without a C-suite salary: the next constraint, then the next. Cancel any month.

If the work stops after stage one, you still hold something the audition was not designed to give you: a costed, evidenced view of what to build and who to hire, ready to take to market or to tender if you choose.

Who you'd be dealing with

- **[Dean], Hong Kong engagement lead.** [One-line credential: specific shipped AI result.] Accountable for delivery, present onsite at an agreed cadence [state cadence before sending], the person you hold accountable.
- **[Julian], UK.** [One-line credential: specific enterprise architecture result.] Leads architecture, decision systems and the operating model, with daily working overlap through Hong Kong afternoons.

One company, senior people only, no juniors learning on your time.

How you control the risk

We have not run this exact programme for a sports data group before, and we would not pretend otherwise. That is precisely why stage one is short, fixed-scope and separately gated: you judge the work, on your problems, before committing to anything more. Before access begins we agree IP ownership, access controls, audit requirements and handover; ACME retains its data and pre-existing IP, and agreed deliverables are documented so they can be operated by ACME or another supplier.

Next step

Thirty minutes with us both. Bring one candidate constraint; in that half hour we will test whether it is valuable and bounded enough for stage one, and show you how we would approach the first fortnight.